

The Order of the Free Gardeners

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As most TFTEM readers would know over the last 350 years there have existed many fraternal organisations that appear to be similar to Freemasonry in their forms and functions. Fraternal organisations such as the Independent Order of Odd Fellows, The Forester's and the Druids have existed for hundreds of years and the extent these fraternal organisations were influenced by Freemasonry, and vice versa, is still a contentious area of debate.

One fraternal organisation that has possibly been in existence for over 400 years, and which displays marked similarities to Freemasonry, is that of the Order of the Free Gardeners. The Free Gardeners are Scottish in origin and may have been meeting as early as 1602, although the earliest conclusive record, a minute book from Haddington, East Lothian, dates from 1676.



In Scotland during the 1600's the formal palace gardens of the Royalty and nobility began to be copied by the landowning classes, often to the disadvantage of the local villagers. Renaissance architecture, formal gardens, sun dials and garden follies became respectable pursuits for the country gentleman. This increased interest in classical landscape gardening and formal garden design necessitated a skilled labour force that was able to construct, maintain and upkeep the ever growing number of horticultural wonders. Bro Bob Cooper suggests that, "...the formation of the Order of Free Gardeners roughly coincides with wealthy landowner's new found interest in landscape design and their employment of a large number of working gardeners..." (Cracking The Freemasons Code, p. 162)

Lodges of Free Gardeners admitted gentlemen "speculative" gardeners into their assemblies but for a higher fee than that paid by the gardeners. The gentleman members gave the Lodges an air of respectability whilst the lodges assisted the gentlemen gardeners with practical skills, advice and seedling stocks. Another crucial aspect of the Free Gardeners activities was the collection of funds for the support of distressed members and their dependants.

The ritual of the Free Gardeners appears to have evolved in a similar fashion to Freemasonry with a new member being initiated with a fairly basic ceremony, but over time this developed into an elaborate three-degree system with peculiar words and secrets restricted to each. Free "*Gardenery*" begins at the Garden of Eden, with Adam as the head Gardener, then follows the 4 rivers that flowed from Eden; the Pison, Gihon, Hiddekel (Tigris) and Euphrates and concludes with King Solomon as the Master Gardener. (Free Gardeners have a wonderful gibe at Masons – only they have the true secrets of KST because they stayed behind to tend the Gardens of Solomon after the Masons had left).

The Free Gardeners were dedicated to mutual support, horticultural practice and knowledge, and rites imbued with moral lessons and esoteric knowledge contained in gardening metaphors. But by the mid 1900's the Order struggled to maintain these tradition activities in part due to various Friendly Society Acts and the development of State welfare. Left with just their ceremonies the Order began to fade so that by the end of the Twentieth Century the Lodge of Free Gardeners that met here in Melbourne was one of the last Free Gardeners' Lodges in the world.